



## Portfolio

[www.mikkelloester.com](http://www.mikkelloester.com)

# Mikkel Køster

Design at Scale · Player-coach · Product Strategist

## About me

With **15+ years** shaping digital products across complex organisations, including **6+ years in design leadership** roles, I build and lead multidisciplinary design teams, set product design direction, and stay **hands-on close to the craft**. My approach bridges **strategic vision and executional craft**: I mentor designers, champion user-centricity at the leadership table, and create the conditions for teams to do their best work.

## In brief

- **Head of Product Design** at [Formalize](#), building design from zero across 2 compliance solutions.
- **Lead UX Designer** at [Maersk](#), leading 12 designers across 20+ product teams on a supply chain platform.
- **Head of UX** at Sleepacy, designing an e-commerce platform from scratch around selling sleep.
- **Experience Design Director** at [1508](#), leading UX on Club Matas and Finansforbundet's digital transformation.
- **Sr. Experience Strategist** at Firstborn in NYC, leading UX on a skincare platform with a unique skin ID system.
- **Senior Experience Strategist** at [NoA Ignite](#) across Pocket Money, the first Danish bank debit card for kids.
- **Digital Advisor** at [Monstarlab](#) across connected product launches, mobile platforms, and the BMW i3 launch.
- **Co-founded** Riot Bernard, an online-only prescription eyewear brand in Shanghai.
- **Interned** at the world-renowned branding agency [Wolff Olins](#) in London.
- **Graduate** of [The Kaospilots](#), a hybrid business and design school in Aarhus.

## Sep 2024 - Now

[www.formalize.com](http://www.formalize.com)

Formalize helps companies stay ahead in the ever-evolving compliance landscape by offering a customizable compliance platform that streamlines governance, risk, and compliance (GRC) processes.

## Formalize

### Head of Product Design

**Built the design function from zero at a hyper-growth compliance startup operating in a trust-critical, regulation-heavy domain, where poor UX isn't just friction, it's a liability.**

- Assembled an exceptionally senior design team from scratch: 2 Principal Product Designers, 1 Staff Designer, and 1 Senior Product Designer.
- Built a component-based design system from scratch, enabling consistent, fast-moving product delivery across two core products.
- Led a full platform redesign — modernizing the experience to feel faster, clearer, and more trustworthy for compliance professionals.
- Moved design from afterthought to strategic partner — embedded in every product team and central to the company's €30M fundraise narrative.

## Jan 2021 - Sep 2024

3 years 3 months

[www.maersk.com](http://www.maersk.com)

Maersk's Supply Chain Platform is an integrated end-to-end supply chain platform that handles complicated logistics processes — allowing customers more time to concentrate on their core business. The vision is to become the global integrator of container logistics.

## Maersk

### Lead UX Designer

**Led the design vision for Maersk's end-to-end supply chain platform — one of Denmark's most ambitious digital transformations, serving 350+ users across 20+ product teams and 260 engineers.**

- Scaled and structured the design team from 6 to 12 members within 6 months, establishing dedicated pillars for Product Design, Design Systems, and UX Research
- Initiated and led Flea Market, a comprehensive design system project that unified patterns platform-wide and drastically reduced technical and design debt
- Untangled complex, data-heavy workflows into intuitive experiences, defining the design principles that aligned 20+ product teams and 260 engineers around a cohesive user experience
- Elevated design to a strategic partner, securing executive-level buy-in for earlier UX involvement in the product cycle and held keynotes to the entire Maersk design community

Jan 2021 - Jul 2021

6 months

Hilding Anders Group is one of the world's leading bed and mattress producers and has embarked on a global, digital transformation, accelerating its mission to "Improve Life Through Sleep" through the brand Sleepacy

Oct 2018 - Jan 2021

2 years 4 months

[www.1508.dk](http://www.1508.dk)

1508 helps companies build valuable services, experiences or processes to accelerate their digital transformation and innovation. 1508 designs what matters.

Apr 2018 - Oct 2018

6 months

Firstborn is a design and innovation company who works with forward-looking companies to shape modern brands for a purpose-driven future. Named #7 best U.S. Design Studio.

Jan 2014 - Jan 2018

4 years

[www.noaignite.com](http://www.noaignite.com)

NoA Ignite designs and builds digital flagship experiences with the power to evoke emotions – the secret sauce to long term growth. NoA Ignite is on Fast Company's prestigious 'Most Innovative Companies' list in 2023!

May 2013 - Jan 2014

9 months

[www.monstarlab.com](http://www.monstarlab.com)

Monstarlab (former Nodes) delivers expert engineering and stunningly designed digital solutions to unleash growth for businesses, customers, and society.

Oct 2011 - Apr 2013

1 year 7 months

[www.thinkhouse.dk](http://www.thinkhouse.dk)

Thinkhouse is a creative communication agency focusing on concept development of trade campaigns across all media platforms.

## Sleepacy

Head of UX

- Designed an e-commerce site from scratch for the Sleepacy brand.
- Drove a new app concept offering "Sleep Services" from initial concept through prototypes to user validation and final design.
- Led external design and development agencies to align on a shared product vision

## 1508

Experience Design Director, Jun 2019 - Jan 2021 | **1 year 8 months**

Senior Experience Strategist, Oct 2018 - Jun 2019 | **9 months**

- **Club Matas:** UX lead on Denmark's largest loyalty app (1.3M members), designed end-to-end from scratch. App Store rating 4.6 from 32,193 reviews.
- **Finansforbundet:** UX lead on digital transformation, conceptualizing and designing 8 new digital products.
- **Dansk Metal:** UX lead on 'Mit Metal', a job search app for unemployed members. 66% of eligible members use it weekly. iOS rating 4.0.

## Firstborn New York

Senior Experience Strategist

- UX and concept lead on a new skincare platform — created a unique skin ID system to personalize product discovery for users
- Led internal teaching on design thinking, hypothesis-driven design, and working more agile in smaller teams

## NoA Ignite

Senior Experience Strategist, Apr 2016 - Jan 2018 | **1 year 10 months**

Digital Strategist, Jan 2014 - Apr 2016 | **2 years 4 months**

- **Danske Bank:** UX and strategy lead on 'Pocket Money', the first app from a major bank combining a debit card with money management for children aged 8–14
- **Varier:** UX lead on an award-winning app promoting healthy sitting habits. Won Experimental category at Danish Digital Awards 2016, displayed at IFA Berlin

## Monstarlab Former Nodes

Digital Advisor

- Advised clients on digital strategy and mobile UX across connected product launches and digital platforms
- Designed the user experience for a platform facilitating the BMW i3 launch in partnership with YouTube
- Conceptualized digital experience concepts for TDC, including consumer support and child safety applications

## Thinkhouse

Creative Project Manager

- Led digital campaign strategy and creative production for major brands including Coca-Cola, Carlsberg, Tuborg, Mars, and Snickers
- Bridged offline and digital execution — integrating campaign events with social and digital media strategies

Mar 2011 - Oct 2011

9 months

Riot Bernard sold stylish prescriptive glasses with a rebellious brand — online only. For every pair bought, we donated a pair to a person in need.

## Riot Bernard

Shanghai

Co-Founder

- Co-founded an online-only prescription eyewear brand with a buy-one-donate-one model, challenging the conventional optical market
- Led brand, marketing, and logistics during launch, including establishing key partnerships during a pivotal stay in Shanghai

Oct 2010 - Jan 2011

4 months

[www.wolffolins.com](http://www.wolffolins.com)

Wolff Olins help create transformative brands that move businesses, people and the world forward.

## Wolff Olins

London

Intern

- Developed creative tools and facilitated co-creation workshops for clients including American Express and Skype at one of the world's leading brand consultancies
- Contributed to concept development and research across client engagements

Aug 2008 - Jun 2011

3 years

[www.kaospilot.dk](http://www.kaospilot.dk)

The Kaospilots is a 3-year hybrid business and design school focusing on leadership and entrepreneurship.

## The Kaospilots

Student

- Three-year hybrid business, design, and leadership programme — ranked among the world's most innovative schools by BusinessWeek and FastCompany
- Focused on leadership, entrepreneurship, and project-based learning in real-world contexts

## Key skills



### Design leadership

Setting direction across complex product ecosystems; design vision, principles, and quality standards.



### Design systems

Building and governing component-based design systems; ensuring consistency across large engineering organizations.



### Team building & mentorship

Hiring, structuring, and growing multidisciplinary design teams; psychological safety and high-talent-density cultures.



### Stakeholder collaboration

Working across product, engineering, and executive stakeholders; communicating design strategy and securing buy-in.



### UX & user research

User-centred design end-to-end; discovery, synthesis, prototyping, testing, and iteration at scale, increasingly supported by AI tools.



### Craft, prototyping & AI

Hands-on in Figma and AI-assisted design tools; from rough concept to high-fidelity interaction design, using AI to accelerate discovery, iteration, and delivery.